

Varied roles

Nurses performed a wide range of medical duties. Much of their work was in disease and infection control, pain management, and the provision of psychological comfort to the wounded. Malaria and dengue fever were prevalent in Vietnam, and both were life-threatening, as were encephalitis, typhus, hepatitis, and other infectious diseases. Nurses managed such cases and sometimes became infected themselves. They would also play a role in caring for those undergoing treatment for drug addiction.

In addition to taking care of American personnel, US nurses participated in humanitarian operations, such as the Medical Civic Action Program (MEDCAP), which provided vital outpatient medical services to South Vietnamese civilians in rural areas.



Earning recognition

US Navy nurses Lieutenant Barbara Wooster, Lieutenant Ruth Mason, and Lieutenant Ann Reynolds become the first women awarded purple heart medals in Vietnam, for surviving the Christmas 1964 Viet Cong bombing in Saigon.

Job stress

Nurses in a war zone suffered many kinds of emotional strains and stresses. The incidence of both post-traumatic stress disorder and emotional problems was high among nurses, who were faced with treating a relentless stream of horrific and painful wounds. The evacuation of severe cases to other hospitals or out of the country meant that nurses and doctors did not have the satisfaction of seeing all patients through to recovery. In addition, nurses experienced social isolation owing to the low number of women in the area and the tensions of living and working in the violent, male-dominated environment of war. These stresses left emotional scars. Nurse Judy Marron, writing about her time in Vietnam, described the horror of seeing cockroaches crawl out of amputees' stumps. One Navy nurse